

How to give a 3 minute talk

With Lucy

Motivation

- We all have to give oral presentations!
 - Internally, externally, at conferences, industry meetings, family Christmas, ...
 - They might be the first interaction you have with a possible future collaborator/employer
- It's not easy to give a good oral presentation!
 - Good presentations take strategy, preparation, and feedback
- Lightning talks/elevator pitches/three-minute theses are a common format
 - They're harder than you think!
- So let's work on our presentation skills together!

Good presentations

- What is the best presentation you have been to?
- Why was it so good?
- Write a couple of notes down 😊

Bad presentations

- What is the worst presentation you have been to?
- Why was it so bad?
- Write a couple of notes down 😊

Share with the group

Writing your presentation: audience

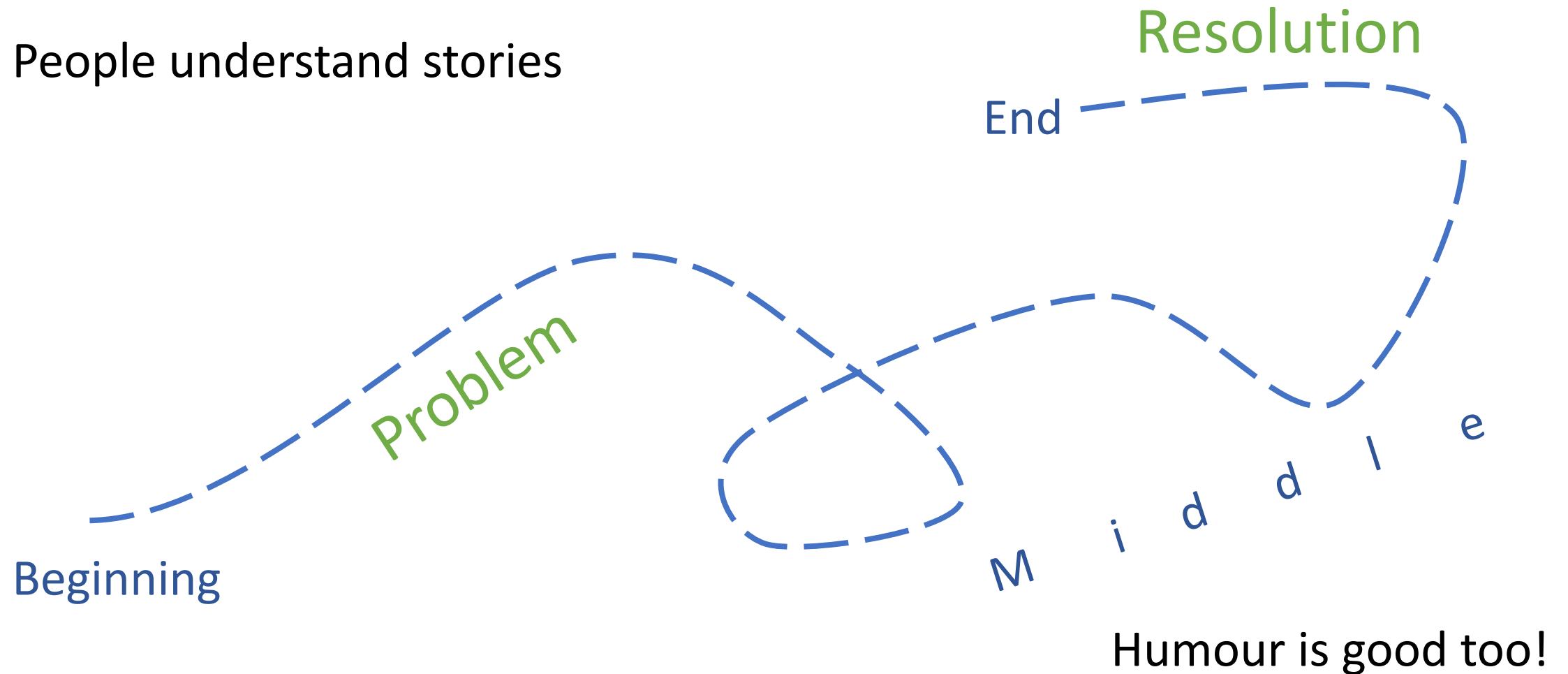
- Who is the audience?
 - Try not to assume too much knowledge
 - Try not to patronise
- Always err on the side of basic: the ideas in your talk might be outside of the context your audience is used to.

Writing your presentation: structure

- K.I.S.S: identify one to three key messages
- Repeat your key messages as you go with signposting:
 - Tell them what you're going to tell them
 - Tell them
 - Tell them what you told them

Writing your presentation: structure

People understand stories



Writing your presentation: message

- What's the most important takeaway from your project/paper/thesis?
- If you can't write down a single takeaway, you're not ready to write your talk!



Visuals

- Legible, clear, concise
- Remove **detail** that you won't be discussing in your talk
- Are your visuals **directly supporting** the messages in your talk?
- Consider how much time your audience is viewing your visuals: is this enough time to take them in?
- Consider using a **graphical abstract**
- **K.I.S.S. !!**

Time to practice!



1. Practice, practice, practice

- Practice.

2. Vocal range

- Speak clearly and use variety in your voice (fast/slow, loud/soft)
- Speak at a conversational pace
- Remember to pause: give the audience time to think about what you are saying.

Time to practice!

3. Body language

- Stand straight and confidently.
- Hold your head up and make eye contact.
- Don't turn your back to the audience.
- (Try and pretend you're having a good time!)
- Practice how you will use your body and hands to emphasise your presentation but note that a 3MT presentation should be delivered from a single spot on stage.

4. Timing

- As you practice, time yourself. What feels like three minutes to you?

Oxford's official 3MT

- Open to DPhil students
- Training: Thursday 30th April, 10am - 12pm
- Applications open: Wednesday 1st April 2026
- Deadline to apply to the competition: 5pm 22nd May 2026
- Oxford Final: Wednesday 17th June 2026

Resources

- <https://www.mpls.ox.ac.uk/public-engagement/three-minute-thesis>
- <https://institute-academic-development.ed.ac.uk/postgraduate/doctoral/3mt/entrants/tips>
- <https://www.sussex.ac.uk/internal/sussex-researcher-school/researcherdev/researchercommunity/threeminthesis/preparing3mt>
- <https://www.cs.ox.ac.uk/files/2263/PresentationSkillsSeminar.pdf>